

KISS: A REVOLUTIONARY MODEL EMPOWERING TRIBALS THROUGH EDUCATION

The tribal communities in India are an integral part of the nation's social and cultural landscape. Yet, they have long faced neglect, marginalisation, and poverty. In Odisha, where nearly a quarter of the population is tribal, these communities are among the most vulnerable, lacking access to education, healthcare, economic opportunities, and government support. Their isolation has made them victims of industrialisation and displacement, pushing many into cycles of deprivation. Alarmingly, some have been drawn into Left Wing Extremism simply to survive.

Amid this bleak scenario, Dr. Achyuta Samanta, who himself faced poverty in childhood, envisioned education as the key to uplifting tribal communities. In 1992, while working as a lecturer, he established the Kalinga Institute of Social Sciences (KISS) with just 125 students. His mission is to provide free, quality education to tribal children, an area often overlooked even by government efforts.



KISS started as a residential school offering not just education but also free food and accommodation. Over time, it evolved into a transformative institution with more than 40,000 students across its campuses and over 40,000 alumni. The institute not only focuses on academics but also promotes sports, music, dance, and skill development. It ensures that graduates leave with degrees and job-ready skills, while also preserving pride in tribal culture and identity.

Over the past 35 years, KISS has grown into a globally recognized model for tribal empowerment. It has received multiple national and international accolades, including UNESCO's International Literacy Prize (2022) and Green Gown Awards, and it has held Special Consultative Status with the UN ECOSOC since 2015. KISS collaborates with several UN agencies to advance shared goals and fulfil the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) 2030.

The impact has been far-reaching. KISS alumni have become doctors, engineers, entrepreneurs, and athletes. The hardworking students are not only securing impressive rankings in UPSC examinations, but they are also succeeding in competitive exams such as JEE with confidence. Most of them are first-generation learners and a source of inspiration for countless young boys and girls in the tribal communities. The institute has significantly reduced child labour, early marriage, dropout rates, and extremist recruitment by creating a nurturing, opportunity-rich environment. Its initiatives promote girl-child education, health, hygiene, scientific temper, and sustainable living. The sports wing has produced 5,000 athletes who've excelled in national and international events.

KISS also generates local employment and has catalysed regional development while preserving tribal heritage. Its success is fuelled by its sister institution, the Kalinga Institute of Industrial Technology (KIIT), which financially supports KISS, making it a self-sustaining model. KIIT is also helping the students realise their dreams in life.

Guided by a 3E mantra—Educate, Enable, Empower—KISS aspires to directly reach over 2 million children in the next decade, ensuring no child is deprived of education due to poverty. Dr. Samanta's visionary leadership and peaceful approach have created a legacy of transformation, making KISS a beacon of hope and a global model for inclusive education and social reform.